

Wage slavery under Unionists

Marginally more fortunate were Black people on abandoned plantations that the Unionists confiscated and returned to working order. Early in the war, the Union army overran some of the South's most profitable plantation districts: the sea islands off Charleston, southern Louisiana, and the fertile lands of the Mississippi River Valley. Enslavers ran to safety behind Confederate lines and left their land and enslaved workers to their fate. Realizing the potential profits to be made, Northern entrepreneurs responded eagerly to the federal government's offers to manage these plantations. In theory, the government would receive the lion's share of the sale of cotton, sugar, or other staple crops, and the Black workers would be paid a fair wage. In reality, plantation managers and local Union army officers conspired to split most of the profits among themselves, and often paid the laborers just enough to keep them working. After "deductions" for food, housing, and clothing, most earned absolutely nothing, and therefore lived an existence akin to enslavement. Local military laws that forbade Black people from being unemployed forced many of them back into the cotton or cane fields, or otherwise face imprisonment.

By the last 18 months of the war, under pressure from both Northern abolitionists and missionaries who were outraged at the "wage slavery" that existed in the Union-occupied South, both Congress and the Union army began to change their policies. Land was the key issue behind this new direction.

Through various pieces of legislation, or under the supervision of Yankee generals, almost 20 percent of the former Confederate territory captured by the Union was given to Black Americans. The prominent abolitionist Wendell Phillips wrote, "Let me confiscate the land of the South, and put it into the hands of Negroes and the white men who fought for it, and I have planted a Union sure to grow as an acorn to become an oak." However, the question remained whether the freedmen would be able to hold on to any land they had gained after the war was over.